Janjua's ENGLISH LIT NOTES



The General Prologue to The Canterbury Tales

GEOFFREY CHAUCER

EXAM EDITION

TEXT · MODERN ENGLISH · MODEL ANSWERS

BY QAISAR IQBAL JANJUA

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Every line with modern English · every pilgrim · model answers

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A Note from the Author

Dear student,

If you have opened this book, you probably have an exam coming, and a poem that looks older than it should. I know that feeling. Chaucer wrote the General Prologue more than six hundred years ago, and at first his English can look like another language. It is not. Once you see what each line means, it becomes one of the liveliest things you will ever study: a whole company of pilgrims, each one drawn so sharply that you could pick them out in a crowd.

I wrote this book to get you there quickly. Every line of Chaucer has its meaning in plain modern English printed right under it, so you never have to guess. After each part of the poem you will find the answers examiners look for, written the way a good answer should be written: clear, to the point, and the right length for the marks.

You do not need to read it from cover to cover. Begin with Questions That Come, find the question that worries you most, and go straight to it. In your last week, stay with Practice and Revise.

I have checked every line and every answer, and I have tried my best to keep this book free of errors. If you do find one, please tell me at qaisar@janjuaslitnotes.com, and I will put it right.

Study well, and walk into that exam with confidence. I am cheering for you.

Qaisar Iqbal Janjua

JANJUA'S ENGLISH LIT NOTES

Contents

A Note from the Author 4

How to Use This Book 7

Questions That Come 8

The Prologue at a Glance 11

The Units: every line, every pilgrim 15

1. The Opening (lines 1 to 42) 15
2. The Knight (lines 43 to 78) 27
3. The Squire (lines 79 to 100) 38
4. The Yeoman (lines 101 to 117) 47
5. The Prioress and her company (lines 118 to 164) 56
6. The Monk (lines 165 to 207) 69
7. The Friar (lines 208 to 269) 80
8. The Merchant (lines 270 to 284) 93
9. The Clerk (lines 285 to 308) 102
10. The Sergeant of the Law (lines 309 to 330) 112
11. The Franklin (lines 331 to 360) 122
12. The Guildsmen and the Cook (lines 361 to 387) 132
13. The Shipman (lines 388 to 410) 142
14. The Doctor of Physic (lines 411 to 444) 152
15. The Wife of Bath (lines 445 to 476) 163
16. The Parson (lines 477 to 528) 174
17. The Ploughman (lines 529 to 541) 186
18. The Miller (lines 542 to 566) 195
19. The Manciple (lines 567 to 586) 205
20. The Reeve (lines 587 to 622) 215
21. The Summoner (lines 623 to 668) 226
22. The Pardoner (lines 669 to 714) 238

23. The Narrator's Apology (lines 715 to 746) 250
24. The Host and the Plan (lines 747 to 858) 261

How Answers Are Marked 278

The Essays 286

1. The Prologue as a picture of fourteenth-century society 287
2. Individuals and types: Chaucer's art of characterisation 291
3. Chaucer and the Church 295
4. The ideal characters 299
5. The opening lines: nature, spring and pilgrimage 303
6. Irony, satire and humour 307
7. Chaucer as "the father of English poetry" 311
8. The narrator: Chaucer the pilgrim and Chaucer the poet 315
9. Women in the Prologue: the Prioress and the Wife of Bath 319
10. The frame: the plan of the Tales and the part of the Host 323
11. Chaucer's style: his English, his verse and the heroic couplet 327
12. Money and the new middle class 331

Practice 335

Revise 350

Further Reading 357

Keys to the Objective Questions 358



The Wife of Bath

A WEALTHY CLOTH-MAKER, FIVE TIMES MARRIED

A bold, deaf, gap-toothed cloth-maker from near Bath, five times wed, who has seen many great shrines and loves company.

Unit 15 · Lines 445-476 (32 lines) · Estate: the rising middle class (cloth trade) · The only laywoman among the pilgrims · Comic, double-edged · Essays 2, 9, 12

The Wife of Bath, drawn for this book from Chaucer's description.

1. Her trade gives her pride: "She passed hem of Ypres and of Gaunt" (448). MONEY
2. Marriage as a career: "Housbondes at chirche-dore she hadde fyve" (460). LOVE
3. Travelling and straying: "She coude muche of wandring by the weye" (467). PILGRIMAGE

EXAMINERS ASK

Write a critical note on the Wife of Bath. (Frequently set) **Answer: Critical note, page 167**

How far does the Wife of Bath stand for a secular and a feminist position? Discuss. (Frequently set) **Answer: Short answer 2, page 169**

Explain lines 453 to 458 with reference to the context. (Frequently set) **Answer: Context answer, page 171**

✓ **A worldly woman of huge energy: the type of the proud wife turned into a living person.**

In this unit: **Text 164** · **Critical note 167** · **Short answers 169** · **Context answer 171** · **Objective questions 172**

CONTEXT

Cloth, marriage and widows. Bath lay in a cloth-making region in the west of England. The finest cloth in Europe came from Flanders, from towns such as Ypres and Ghent, so to surpass them was the highest praise. Weddings took place at the church door: the couple made their vows in the porch and then went in for Mass. In law a married woman's goods belonged to her husband, but a widow could own property and run a trade in her own name. A woman married five times might inherit from several husbands and grow rich.

The text

The Wife of Bath LINES 445 TO 476

A good WYF was ther of bisyde BATHE,
There was a good WIFE from near BATH,

But she was som-del deef, and that was scathe.
Sadly, she was a little hard of hearing.

Of clooth-making she hadde swiche an haunt,
Her skill at weaving cloth was so great

She passed hem of Ypres and of Gaunt.
That she surpassed the weavers of Ypres and Ghent.

In al the parisshe wyf ne was ther noon
There was not a wife in her whole parish

That to the offring bifore hir sholde goon;
Who dared to go up with her offering ahead of her;

And if ther dide, certeyn, so wrooth was she,
And if anyone did, she was certainly so angry

That she was out of alle charitee.
That she lost all her charity.

WORDS
445 bisyde: **beside** · **446** som-del deef: **somewhat deaf** · **446** scathe: **a pity** · **447** haunt: **skill, practice** · **448** passed: **surpassed** · **448** hem of: **those of** · **449** wyf: **woman** · **450** offring: **offering at Mass** · **450** bifore hir: **before her** · **451** wrooth: **angry** · **452** out of alle charitee: **beyond all charity**

453 Hir coverchiefs ful fyne were of ground;
Her headscarves were finely woven;

454 I dorste swere they weyeden ten pound
I dare swear they weighed ten pounds,

455 That on a Sonday were upon hir heed.
Those that were on her head on a Sunday.

456 Hir hosen weren of fyn scarlet reed,
Her stockings were a fine bright red,

457 Ful streite y-teyd, and shoos ful moiste and newe.
Tightly fastened, and her shoes were soft and new.

458 Bold was hir face, and fair, and reed of hewe.
Her face was bold and handsome, and red in colour.

WORDS
453 coverchiefs: **head-kerchiefs** · **453** of ground: **in texture** · **454** dorste swere: **dare swear** · **454** weyeden: **weighed** · **456** hosen: **stockings** · **456** scarlet reed: **scarlet red** · **457** streite y-teyd: **tightly tied** · **457** moiste: **supple** · **458** reed of hewe: **red in colour**

459 She was a worthy womman al hir lyve,
All her life she was a woman of some importance;

460 Housbondes at chirche-dore she hadde fyve,
Five husbands she had married at the church door,

461 Withouten other companye in youthe;
Leaving aside the other company she kept when young;

462 But therof nedeth nat to speke as nouthe.
But we need not go into that at present.

463 And thryes hadde she been at Ierusalem;
And she had been to Jerusalem three times;

464 She hadde passed many a straunge streem;
She had crossed many a foreign river;

465 At Rome she hadde been, and at Boloigne,
She had been to Rome, and to Boulogne,

466 In Galice at seint Iame, and at Cologne.
To Saint James in Galicia (Compostela), and to Cologne.

467 She coude muche of wandring by the weye.
She knew a great deal about wandering along the road.

468 Gat-tothed was she, soothly for to seye.
She was gap-toothed, to tell the truth.

WORDS

459 worthy: **respectable** · **459** al hir lyve: **all her life** · **460** chirche-dore: **church door** · **461** Withouten: **not counting** · **461** other companye: **other lovers** · **462** therof: **of that** · **462** nedeth nat: **there is no need** · **462** as nouthe: **just now** · **463** thryes: **three times** · **464** passed: **crossed** · **464** straunge streem: **foreign river** · **466** Galice: **Galicia (Spain)** · **466** seint Iame: **Saint James (Compostela)** · **467** coude muche: **knew much** · **467** wandring by the weye: **travelling; also straying from the right path** · **468** Gat-tothed: **gap-toothed** · **468** soothly: **truly**

469 Up-on an amblere esily she sat,
She sat comfortably on an easy-paced horse,

470 Y-wimpled wel, and on hir heed an hat
Her head well wrapped in a wimple, and on her head a hat

471 As brood as is a bokeler or a targe;
Broad as a buckler or a round targe;

472 A foot-mantel aboute hir hipes large,
An outer skirt around her large hips,

473 And on hir feet a paire of spores sharpe.
And a pair of sharp spurs on her heels.

474 In felawschip wel coude she laughe and carpe.
In company she knew well how to laugh and chatter.

475 Of remedyes of love she knew per-chaunce,
She knew, as it happened, the remedies of love,

476 For she coude of that art the olde daunce.
For she knew all the old steps of that dance.

WORDS

469 amblere: **ambling horse** · **470** Y-wimpled: **wearing a wimple** · **471** bokeler: **buckler** · **471** targe: **round shield** · **472** foot-mantel: **riding skirt** · **472** hipes: **hips** · **473** spores: **spurs** · **474** carpe: **chatter, talk** · **475** remedyes of love: **cures for love** · **475** per-chaunce: **as it happened** · **476** coude: **knew** · **476** olde daunce: **old game, old tricks**

Critical note

Write a critical note on the Wife of Bath.

Critical note · about 300 words

✓ **Answer.** The Wife of Bath is the most alive woman in the Prologue. Chaucer makes her live through a heap of solid detail that the narrator praises and the reader judges. She is the only laywoman among the pilgrims, a woman outside the Church, and she is drawn with every feature made bigger than life.

Her body tells her story. The narrator opens with praise, “A good WYF was ther of bisyde BATHE” (445), and at once adds a flaw: she is a little deaf (446). Her own Prologue, later in the Tales, explains that her fifth husband struck her on the ear. She is “Gat-tothed” (468), gap-toothed, which physiognomy, the old science of reading character from the

face, took as a sign of a bold and loving nature. She has "hipes large" (472) and wears "a paire of spores sharpe" (473). Every detail can be seen and touched.

The praise carries a hidden criticism. She is "a worthy womman al hir lyve" (459), but her worth is counted in husbands. The narrator then refuses to speak of her "other companye in youthe" (461), and so makes the reader think of nothing else. Her charity fails if another wife goes first to the offering (451-452). She knows "the olde daunce" (476) of love, and experience, not innocence, is her pride.

Critics read her both as a type and as a person. Jill Mann showed that the portraits follow and transform estates satire, medieval writing that gave each class and calling its typical faults. Pride, show and a roving eye were the stock faults such writers gave to wives. Chaucer keeps them but gives her so much energy that she outgrows the type. Dryden saw the people of every age in the pilgrims: "We have our forefathers and great-grandames all before us, as they were in Chaucer's days."

Verdict: the Wife of Bath is the worldly wife of old satire made into a person, judged with a smile, not a sermon.

329 words

Short answers

What do the Wife of Bath's cloth-making and her anger at the offering show?

5 marks · short answer

✓ **Answer.** They show a woman whose pride rests on her success in trade and who carries that pride into church. Cloth-making was the great industry of her region, and she is so skilled that "She passed hem of Ypres and of Gaunt" (448). Ypres and Ghent were the famous cloth towns of Flanders, so the claim is a large boast, perhaps the narrator's exaggeration. Her trade gives her money and standing. At Mass the people of a parish went up with their offerings in order of rank. No wife in her parish dares to go before her. If one does, she grows so angry that she loses all charity (451-452). The joke is sharp. Charity, the love of one's neighbour, is the heart of Christian worship, and she loses it during worship over a question of rank. Success in business has become pride in church.

144 words

How far does the Wife of Bath stand for a secular and a feminist position? Discuss.

5 marks · short answer

✓ **Answer.** The Wife of Bath represents a secular position fully and a feminist position only in part. Secular means concerned with this world, not with the Church. Her standing comes from trade and marriage, not from faith. Feminist, in the modern sense, means claiming equal rights for women. In favour of the claim, she earns her own money

as a cloth-maker and has chosen five husbands (460). She rides with spurs, and "In felawschip wel coude she laughe and carpe" (474). In a society that asked women to be silent and obedient, that is real independence. Against the claim, the word feminist belongs to a much later age. She wants to go first at the offering, not to change the order of rank. A male narrator also draws her with old beliefs about women's appetites. She is independent, but she has no plan to change the place of women.

148 words

COMMON MISTAKE

The mistake. Writing that the Wife argues, in the General Prologue, that wives should rule their husbands. **The correction.** That argument comes in her own Prologue, later in the Tales. In the General Prologue she does not speak; the narrator describes her (445-476). **Why it costs marks.** A question on "The Prologue" wants evidence from these lines; quoting the wrong text weakens every point.

What do the Wife of Bath's pilgrimages tell us about her?

5 marks · short answer

✓ **Answer.** Her pilgrimages show a woman of wealth, courage and appetite for the world, for whom the road matters as much as the shrine. "And thryes hadde she been at Ierusalem" (463), a long, costly and dangerous journey that few people made even once. She has also seen Rome, Boulogne, the shrine of Saint James at Compostela in Galicia, and Cologne, which claimed the bones of the Three Kings (465-466). Only a woman with money and freedom could make such journeys. The next line holds a pun, a play on two meanings: she knew much "of wandring by the weye" (467). She knows a great deal about travelling, and also about

straying from the right path. Her journeys seem to offer company and pleasure more than penance, the sorrow for sin that a pilgrimage was meant to show. Canterbury is one more stop on a long road.

146 words

Context answer

Lines 453 to 458

> Hir coverchiefs ful fyne were of ground;
> I dorste swere they weyeden ten pound
> That on a Sonday were upon hir heed.
> Hir hosen weren of fyn scarlet reed,
> Ful streite y-teyd, and shoos ful moiste and newe.
> Bold was hir face, and fair, and reed of hewe. (453-458)

Reference to context · 200 to 250 words

✓ **Answer.**

Reference. These lines come from the portrait of the Wife of Bath in the General Prologue to The Canterbury Tales by Geoffrey Chaucer. She is a cloth-maker from near Bath and the only laywoman among the pilgrims. The narrator speaks.

Context. Just before, we learn that she outdoes the weavers of Ypres and Ghent and grows angry if any wife goes before her to the offering (447-452). Just after, the narrator calls her “a worthy womman” (459) and counts her five husbands (460).

Explanation. Her headcloths were finely woven; the narrator would swear that those she wore on a Sunday weighed ten pounds. Her stockings were of fine scarlet, tightly tied, and her shoes were soft and new. Her face was bold, handsome and red. “coverchiefs” (453) are headcloths, “hosen” (456) are stockings, and “moiste” (457) means supple, not wet. The technique is dress as character. The narrator promised to report each pilgrim’s “array” (41), and here the clothes speak. The oath “I dorste swere” (454) introduces hyperbole, deliberate exaggeration: ten pounds of linen on one head is absurd, and the absurdity measures her vanity. Sunday, the day of worship, becomes her day for display. Scarlet was a costly cloth, and the red of her stockings returns in her face. “Bold” (458) sums up both.

Critical comment. Six lines show a woman who dresses to be seen, even in church. Kittredge’s words on the whole Tales, in Chaucer and His Poetry (Harvard University Press, 1915), fit her: “The Pilgrims are not static: they move and live.”

256 words

Objective questions

Choose one answer. Keys are at the end of the book.

71. The Wife of Bath surpasses the cloth-makers of Ypres and Gaunt, towns in:

(a) Italy
(b) Spain
(c) France
(d) Flanders

72. How many husbands has the Wife of Bath married at the church door?

(a) three
(b) four
(c) five
(d) six

73. The Wife of Bath's hat is as broad as:

(a) a buckler or a targe
(b) a spade
(c) a church door
(d) a ship's sail

74. "Gat-tothed was she, soothly for to seye" (468) means that she was:

(a) toothless
(b) gap-toothed
(c) buck-toothed
(d) gold-toothed

75. "In Galice" (466) the Wife of Bath visited the shrine of:

(a) Saint Peter
(b) Saint Thomas
(c) Saint James
(d) Saint Julian

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This was a free sample of

The General Prologue to The Canterbury Tales

GEOFFREY CHAUCER

EXAM EDITION

THE FULL BOOK HAS

- **24 units**, one for each pilgrim or section of the poem: the complete text with a plain modern English line under every line and word notes beneath
- In every unit: a character card, a background box, a critical note, three short answers, a model context answer and five objective questions
- **Twelve model essays** on the questions examiners set most often, each with a marked shorter version
- **180 objective questions**, practice questions, one-line facts, a quotation bank and a last-night checklist
- Original drawings of every pilgrim, in one house style

The text is Skeat's edition (Oxford, 1900), with obvious misprints corrected, and every quotation and line number is checked against it.

COMING SOON ON AMAZON

Paperback (6 x 9 in) and Kindle ebook

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